the bundle, take all the magazines apart in neat little stacks, count them to make sure he had the right number of each, place each little stack in the right place in the newsstand, removing, as he did so, any previous issues of that sort left over. He put the previous issues in another place to stack up and return to the distributor. All this was simple, but it took time, and my father preferred to cut the bundle when things were slow in the store and not, as I invariably did, the instant they arrived. (He always liked it better when I had to be in school at the time the Astoundings arrived, and he always saved me my copy.)

On Tuesday, May 10, 1938, the day I expected Astounding under the new second-Wednesday-of-the-month dispensation my father was particularly annoyed because, having cut the bundle, I didn't find any copies of my magazine. It had been cut for nothing, he complained.

If he was annoyed, I was terrified. On May 11, my diary begins, "Another day has gone by, and no Astounding. I never realized before how much these science-fiction magazines mean to me."

My terror, of course, was that Astounding might have ceased publication. On May 12, in desperation, I invested a nickel for a phone call to Street & Smith, Inc., the publishers of Astounding. I was solemnly assured by whoever it was at the other end that the magazine had not ceased publication. I decided it would probably arrive the next Tuesday, having returned to the older schedule.

There was nothing to do but wait for Tuesday, which I did in a rather distraught way. It sounds silly to have taken on so about a magazine, but each person has his own standards of what, exactly, counts for much or little in his life. I would stand there behind the cash register, handing out packs of cigarettes, and making change, and I would find myself staring at the magazine rack at the other end of the store and

deciding that as long as Astounding wasn't there in its accustomed place, life was not worth living.

And on Tuesday May 17, Astounding didn't come.

3

I had spent days planning my course of procedure in this case. I picked up tips now and then, when delivering an order or calling someone to the phone, and I had been saving them of late, feeling that they were my money. I had